Sycamore Square — Engineering Review and City Pre-Application Package

Oct 18, 2026 ·

Purpose

This package asks a licensed engineering firm to confirm the concept plans, and the City of Memphis to say at a pre-application meeting what approvals the plan needs. The drawings come from county GIS data and the building's 1997 tenant plans, not a survey. They show what the owners intend to build and where the open questions are. They are not construction, permit or conveyance documents.

The plan turns the existing 127,634 SF single-story building at 1699–1735 Sycamore View Road into five parts:

- Two event halls, Hall A and Hall B, with kitchens and a shared dining room
- A kids' recreation center
- Small-shop retail
- Flex space
- An optional fuel station with a convenience store on the frontage

We need three things from this round:

1. **From the engineers:** a fee proposal and a short written review that confirms or corrects the layout, flood strategy, parking and site access.
2. **From the City:** the approval path for each use and each parcel, the flood rules that apply, and the studies the City will require.
3. **From both:** a list of anything that would stop the plan or change its cost by more than 10%.

Site and building facts

Every fact below needs confirmation by survey, title or the City. The confidence column says how far each one can be trusted today.

Item	What we have	Source	Confidence
Parcels	088066 00027 (9.69 ac, main building), 00020 (5800 Summer, 1.33 ac), 00021 (5810 Summer, 0.47 ac), 00024 (1717 Sycamore View frontage, 0.38 ac)	Shelby County parcel layer, Oct 2026	Medium: tax polygons, not a survey
Site area	11.88 ac on recorded lines; broker states 11.72 ac	County GIS; offering memorandum	Low until ALTA survey
Excluded neighbors	Family Dollar (1745 Sycamore View) and the brick retail building (5828 Summer). No work is shown on either.	County GIS; site visit photos	High
Building	127,634 SF listed floor area; ~132,600 SF drawn footprint; single story, ~24 ft roof; built 1984, renovated 1996–97	Offering memorandum; county GIS	Medium
Structure	Area A (south) columns on a ~44 × 44 ft grid; 1-hour rated wall about 270 ft north of the south wall	1997 Sitel tenant plans, sheets A2.1 and A2.2	Medium: ±10 ft, field check needed
Fire protection	Sprinkler riser room on the west wall of Area A	1997 Sitel plans	Medium
Zoning	CMU-3 on 00027, 00020 and 00021; residential and agricultural zoning behind the building to the west	County GIS zoning layer	Medium; 00024 not yet confirmed

Item	What we have	Source	Confidence
Flood	FEMA Zone AE, FIRM panel 47157C0311G. About 74% of the footprint and about 4.0 ac of the site fall in the flood layer. Base flood elevation not found.	City flood layer copy; county record	Medium: effective FEMA map not yet pulled
Former use on frontage	2,086 SF "mini lube" building, built 1981, recorded on 00024 in the 2017 county flight. It no longer appears in current imagery.	County planimetrics	High that it existed; condition unknown
Parking	909 spaces claimed by the broker; ~769 counted from GIS paint lines	Offering memorandum; county planimetrics	Low until counted on site
Roads and traffic	Sycamore View 30,226, Summer Ave (US-70) 21,290, Pleasant View 10,064 vehicles a day	Offering memorandum	Low: dates and sources not given
Utilities	800 kW generator listed; utility sizes unknown	Offering memorandum	Low

Proposed program

The whole existing building is reused and its outer walls do not move. A new 4,000 SF convenience store is the only new building, and it is optional. Areas are gross planning budgets; net usable areas come after a measured interior survey.

Part	Gross area	What it contains
Hall A suite	20,563 SF	11,000 SF main room (132 × 83 ft between column lines, 2 interior columns), foyer, two 700 SF family suites, guest toilets

Part	Gross area	What it contains
Hall B suite	17,009 SF	Same 11,000 SF main room and suites; own entrance and toilets
Kitchens	3,895 SF	Two ~1,950 SF catering kitchens, one per hall, each with rear receiving; a controlled door lets one caterer run both
Dining and gallery	4,484 SF	2,400 SF reservable dining room plus a guest gallery linking the two foyers
Service support	1,779 SF	Storage, staff, janitorial
Kids' recreation	18,000 SF	Public play and party rooms with their own entrance, plus a private zone reached from Hall A
Retail	35,000 SF	20–25 storefronts along the north and east walls
Flex	26,904 SF	Shell held in reserve with its own west entrance
Building total	**127,634 SF**	Matches the listed floor area
C-store (optional, new)	4,000 SF	80 × 50 ft store

The halls run three ways. One family can book Hall A and Hall B together for a single wedding, with guests split between two rooms. Two unrelated events can run at once, each with its own entrance, kitchen and staff. Or both halls can open to each other as one coordinated event.

Fuel has two candidate locations; no decision is made yet.

- **F1, frontage (preferred):** a 72 × 40 ft canopy with six fueling positions and a 40 × 20 ft tank area on the 1717 frontage, about 91 ft from Sycamore View. It is reached from the existing throat drive, and the store sits beside it on the main parcel. It sits on the former quick-lube pad.
- **F2, 5800 Summer (fallback):** store and canopy as one block on the pad parcel beside Summer Avenue, outside the mapped flood area.
- **No fuel:** the frontage stays parking and landscaping.

Questions for the engineering team

The flood answers come first, because the 50% rule can decide the whole budget. Each row names what we want back.

Discipline	Question	What we want back
Survey	What are the true boundary, easements, encroachments and acreage of the four parcels? Do any recorded access or parking agreements bind the site?	ALTA/NSPS survey with Table A items 1–4, 6–11, 13, 16–19
Survey and flood	What are the building's lowest adjacent grade and finished floor elevations against the base flood elevation?	FEMA elevation certificate
Flood	If the floor is above the BFE, can a LOMA remove the building from the flood zone? If not, can the building be dry-floodproofed to the level the City requires, and at what cost?	Written flood strategy with a cost range
Flood	How will improvement cost and structure value be counted for the 50% substantial-improvement test, and does Memphis count improvements over several years?	Memo agreed with the floodplain administrator
Structural	Can the 2 interior columns in each hall be removed with transfer beams across about 88 ft, and what would that cost against designing around them?	Feasibility letter and budget
Structural	Can the roof carry new rooftop units, kitchen hoods and any rigging loads? What is the clear height?	Roof framing check and field measurements

Discipline	Question	What we want back
Architectural and code	What are the occupancy groups and occupant loads? How many exits and toilets do the halls, play center and retail need, and what fire separations? Does the 1-hour wall stay useful?	Code analysis and a measured floor plan
Fire protection	Can the existing sprinkler system be extended or does it need replacement? Is a fire pump needed? What fire alarm is required for assembly use?	Sprinkler and alarm narrative with a budget
Mechanical, electrical, plumbing	Is electrical service big enough for two kitchens, a play center and retail? Can the generator be reused? Is there enough sewer and grease-interceptor capacity?	MEP condition report
Civil	How many legal parking spaces are there? Is detention required (City engineering requires it for most projects over one acre)? What repaving is needed?	Parking count, drainage memo and civil budget
Traffic	Do the driveways work for peak event arrivals and fuel trucks? Does Summer Avenue (US-70) access need a TDOT permit? Is a traffic study needed?	Trip-generation report and access memo
Environmental	Did the former quick-lube leave tanks, oil or contamination on the frontage?	Phase I ESA (ASTM E1527-21); Phase II if flagged
Fuel (if pursued)	Do the F1 or F2 layouts work for setbacks, canopy clearance, tank placement, tanker turning and queuing?	Fuel site plan from the engineer or fuel operator

Questions for the City pre-application meeting

We want each answer in writing, in the meeting notes or a follow-up letter. Ask Memphis and Shelby County Division of Planning and Development (DPD) to bring zoning, City Engineering, the floodplain administrator, Fire and Building (Construction Code Enforcement) staff to one meeting. Ask TDOT separately about Summer Avenue.

Department	Question	Answer we need
Zoning (DPD)	Are event / banquet halls, indoor recreation, retail, restaurants, supervised child care and fuel sales allowed by right in CMU-3? Which need a special use permit or a planned development?	Use-by-use list, and a zoning verification letter for each parcel
Zoning (DPD)	What zoning applies to the 1717 frontage (00024)? Is any planned-development overlay recorded on the site?	Zoning letter for 00024
Zoning (DPD)	What landscape buffer, screening, setbacks and lighting rules apply along the residential edge to the west?	Code sections and widths
Zoning (DPD)	How many parking spaces do the halls, play center and retail need? Is a shared-parking reduction allowed when the uses peak at different times?	Required count and the reduction method
Zoning (DPD)	Can the uses be approved through Administrative Site Plan Review, or does the project go to the Land Use Control Board? How long does each route take?	The approval route and a timeline

Department	Question	Answer we need
Zoning (DPD)	Can 5800 and 5810 Summer be sold or financed separately as they stand, or is a plat needed?	Yes / no, with the process
Zoning (DPD)	Is the 2025–26 code update likely to change any of these answers before we apply?	Staff view and the adoption date
Floodplain administrator	What is the base flood elevation here, and what elevation does Memphis require for a nonresidential floor or floodproofing? (City engineering checklists cite 24 inches above BFE under UDC 8.8.)	The required design elevation
Floodplain administrator	How is the 50% substantial-improvement test applied here: which costs count, which value is used, and over what period?	Written method
City Engineering	Is stormwater detention required for repaving and site work on an existing paved lot? Which drainage basin is this?	Detention yes / no and the basin
City Engineering and Traffic	Are new or changed curb cuts on Sycamore View acceptable? Is a traffic study needed for the event peak?	Access feedback and study scope
Fire Marshal	What fire lanes, hydrants and fire flow do assembly use and a fuel canopy need?	Access and water requirements

Department	Question	Answer we need
Building (Construction Code Enforcement)	Which building code edition applies to the change of use? Will the City accept phased permits (shell, then each tenant)?	Code edition and permit sequence
TDOT	Does any driveway work on Summer Avenue (US-70) need a state permit?	Permit yes / no and the contact
Health Department	What does each catering kitchen need for a food permit, and what grease-interceptor size?	Permit requirements

Drawings and files to bring

Print the master plan at 36 × 24 in, and send the PDF and DXF ahead of the meeting. All sheets are revision R4.1 (18 Oct 2026). The boundary on every sheet follows the recorded lines of the four parcels.

Sheet	Title	Use in the meeting
C-1	Existing conditions and parcel verification	Parcels, flood layer, excluded neighbors, former quick-lube pad
C-2	Proposed master site plan	Where each use sits on the site
A-1	Proposed building division plan	Floor areas, hall rooms, existing columns
A-2	Event operations	How Hall A and Hall B run separately or together
C-3	Parking and vehicle circulation	Arrivals, parking, service and fire access
C-4	Fuel and convenience-store test	F1 and F2 fuel layouts
A-3	Preliminary architectural improvements	New entrances inside the existing shell

Sheet	Title	Use in the meeting
F-1	Space allocation, budget ranges and phasing	Area budget by use, cost ranges and phases

Also bring:

- Sycamore_Square_Master_Plan_R4.pdf (the eight sheets above)
- Sycamore_Square_Georeferenced_R4.dxf (CAD, Tennessee State Plane coordinates, EPSG:2274)
- The 1997 Sitel tenant plans, sheets A2.1 and A2.2
- Sycamore_Square_Legal_and_Regulatory_Findings.pdf
- This package, printed, with room to write the City's answers next to each question

Next steps

Order the elevation certificate and survey first: the flood answer sets the budget, and every other engineer needs the survey. All of this fits inside a normal due-diligence period if it starts in the first week.

1. Send this package and the PDFs to two or three civil engineering firms that work in Memphis, and ask each for a fee proposal for the reviews above.
2. Order the ALTA survey with topography and an elevation certificate. Order the Phase I environmental assessment the same week.
3. Ask DPD for a pre-application meeting, naming the departments listed above. Send the drawings at least a week ahead.
4. Hold the meeting. Write the City's answer next to each question, and ask staff to confirm the notes by email.
5. Request the written zoning verification letters and the floodplain administrator's method for the 50% test.
6. Bring the survey, flood answer, City answers and engineering review together into revision R5 of the plans, and update both feasibility studies with real costs.
7. Decide go / no-go on the purchase before the due-diligence period ends.

Sources

- City of Memphis Engineering, 2025 Standards and Guidelines. Detention for projects of one acre or more, curb-cut permits, and the finished-floor note of 24 inches above BFE under UDC 8.8.
- Memphis and Shelby County application process (UDC Chapter 9 summary, MTAS). Application types, Land Use Control Board review and notice periods.
- Shelby County, Administrative Site Plan Review. The administrative site plan route.
- 44 CFR 59.1, NFIP definitions. Definition of substantial improvement.
- Shelby County ReGIS parcel, zoning, planimetric and flood layers, queried 17 Oct 2026; 1997 Sitel tenant plans A2.1 and A2.2; Avison Young offering memorandum.